



External Candidate – UX Persona

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Quick Card



Definition:

The External Candidate refers to an individual seeking job opportunities with a new employer. Their circumstances may vary - for example, an unemployed job seeker versus one who seeks to move away from current employment - but they share key jobs-to-be-done, from preparation for the job search through to accepting or declining an offer.



User Type:

Worker 

Key Collaborators:

Manager 

HR Professional 

Most Relevant Jobs To Be Done (JTBD)

1. **Prepare for job search**

2. **Find a job that is relevant to me**

3. **Determine if I am right for the job**

4. **Determine if the job is right for me**

5. **Apply for job**

6. **Track my job application**

7. **Engage with hiring organization throughout**

8. **Accept or decline offer**



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Most Relevant Jobs To Be Done (JTBD)

1. **Prepare for job search**

2. **Find a job that is relevant to me**

3. **Determine if I am right for the job**

the application process



Key Pain Points & Opportunities

How to use this document

UX Persona Breakdown

External Candidate Definition

The External Candidate refers to an individual seeking job opportunities with a new employer. Their circumstances may vary - for example, an unemployed job seeker versus one who seeks to move away from current employment - but they share key jobs-to-be-done, from preparation for the job search through to accepting or declining an offer.

While the JTBD performed by the External Candidate do not change by circumstance, motivations and behaviors do. These nuances are reflected in the sections below.

Key Collaborators

- The External Candidate typically collaborates with the Manager user type (the Hiring Manager for the job to which the Candidate has applied), typically during the interview process (although the Hiring Manager will typically have reviewed the External Candidate's application or résumé leading up to that point)
- Depending on the organizational context, the External Candidate will interact with one or more HR Professionals, including:
 - The Recruiter responsible for filling the job requisition
 - A dedicated *Sourcer*, in organizations where there is a specialist role for filling the organization's talent pipeline
 - An Interview Coordinator, in organizations where there is a specialist role for arranging interviews on behalf of Candidates, Recruiters, and Hiring Managers

Most Relevant Jobs To Be Done (JTBD)

Prepare for job search ▾

- **Workflows / How this job gets done:**
 - Update résumé / CV
 - Research typical requirements for desired job role or field
 - Use tools such as ChatGPT to optimize résumé / CV

- **Scenarios**

When preparing for a job search:

- The proliferation of resources - in particular, articles and social media accounts geared towards a job seeking audience - is providing candidates with insights into how applications are processed
- The External Candidate uses these resources to understand how they can optimize their application for the best chances of success, for example:
 - Use of keywords that résumés are screened on
 - Most appropriate format to 'get past' automated screening tools
- These resources include articles on blogs and websites (e.g. LinkedIn) as well as influencer accounts that specialize in recruiting practice
- The External Candidate can also leverage tools for the actual building of a résumé, too, for example:
 - Use of templates for résumé building
 - Use of Generative AI to build the résumé based on an understanding of the requirements for the role
- **Dimensions of difference** among External Candidates: the length of time it takes to [Prepare for Job Search](#) will depend on:
 - The length of time an individual has been out of the workforce
 - And/or whether the desired job role/field represents a change from current or past employment

- **Quotes & Additional Insight**

"I read on some pages that they follow some keywords for a Data Analyst job, and the search (for a candidate) is refined based on that. So if they don't find those words in the résumé - like, if I talk about data analysis, the main terms are like, pre-processing, cleaning the data, and so on - the application is filtered out."[\[1\]](#)

Read more in the [Quote Library](#) for [Prepare for Job Search](#)



Candidates are using generative AI in their applications - as much as 50% of the candidate population, based on some estimates - for tasks such as generating or improving cover

letters; generating a writing sample; and generating answers to assessment questions.[\[2\]](#)

Find a job that is relevant to me

- **Workflows / How this job gets done:**

- Job board search (e.g. Indeed.com, Monster.com, LinkedIn)
- Direct search on company career site
- Search engine query using important job criteria
- Saving specific jobs or search criteria
- Responding to push notifications from saved jobs

- **Scenarios**

When finding a job that is relevant to me:

- The External Candidate increasingly relies on a mobile device for job searches, owing to the ubiquity of the device, meaning that the Candidate can search for a job in many settings
- Candidates often start broad with job sites for inspiration, given the wide breadth of available jobs that can be found. From there, the Candidate will narrow the search using their own criteria and available filters
- The External Candidate must consider a range of variables before the search begins, such as:
 - What kind of job do I want? What am I good at? What do I want to do?
 - What kind of commute do I want?
 - What hours do I want to work?
 - How much do I need to be paid?
 - Who do I want to work for?
- Depending on the capabilities of the platform that the External Candidate uses, these criteria can be saved, along with optional push notifications with job alerts that match the criteria

- In the absence of available filters, the External Candidate may perform a search engine query containing one or more criteria (e.g. “Software Developer jobs in Palo Alto”)
- **Dimensions of difference** among External Candidates: the longer the job search, the more willing a job seeker is to make tradeoffs in requirements, compared to those who are being more methodical to ensure that the job is the “right fit”. A Candidate that has been looking for longer is also likely to increase the number of discrete search terms in order to increase number of results

- **Quotes & Additional Insight**

“Most days it’s the mixed emotions of excitement and, you know, the melancholy feel of, like, here we go again.” [3]

Read more in the [Quote Library](#) for [Find a job that is relevant to me](#)



In a benchmarking study[4] of Fortune 500 websites, the search functionality was found to be limited:

- 12% of career sites had a type-ahead search feature available
- 11% of career sites’ search functionality understood the context of the keyword and separated it with proper grouping (e.g. keyword, location, category)
- 78% of career sites’ search functionality only showed results for what was typed — not similar suggestions

Determine if I am right for the job

Note: The following two JTBD - [Determine if I am right for the job](#) and [Determine if the job is right for me](#) are related and sequential. Recent internal research suggested that the External Candidates begin with the former and then, once satisfied

that they are qualified for the job, try to determine whether or not the job is a good fit for the individual.

- **Workflows / How this job gets done:**

- Examine the job requirements listed on the job posting
- Understand what skills, experience, and qualifications are necessary to get role

- **Scenarios**

When determining if I am right for the job:

- The External Candidate finds it more straightforward to understand if *they* are right for the job (i.e. likely to be a suitable candidate, with a good chance of success) than to understand if the job is right for *them*
- The indicators that the External Candidate looks out for when scanning the job description are requirements in respect of:
 - Skills
 - Experience
 - Education/Qualifications
- **Dimensions of difference** among External Candidates: Candidates acknowledge that it's unlikely that they will fulfill every requirement for a given job, so they seek to establish whether or not they meet a threshold, past which they could go on to develop the right skills in order to be able to perform the job duties. However:
 - For individuals who have been searching for a long time, a “quantity over quality” mindset kicks in: they will regularly apply for any job that they think they can do, even if they don’t have that experience. They believe that the more jobs they apply for, the better the odds are at getting hired somewhere
 - In contrast, those who are looking for “the right fit” take the time to be methodical and thorough in their job search. More research is carried out into the jobs and possible employers, and this individual only applies for jobs where they know they can hit the ground running

- **Quotes & Additional Insight**

“There should be a clear indication of the desired skills so that the candidate has a clear picture in mind: ‘Yes, I have these particular skills.’”[\[5\]](#)

Read more in the [Quote Library](#) for [Determine if I am right for the job](#)



Candidates want to understand what a successful candidate profile looks like for the job, with benchmarking data showing an increase in importance by 75% in 2022 compared to the previous year.[\[6\]](#)

Determine if the job is right for me

- **Workflows / How this job gets done:**

- Evaluate the tangible attributes of the job/company, particularly:
 - Compensation
 - Location
 - Flexibility in when and where the work happens
- Evaluate the intangible aspects, particularly those related to the employee experience:
 - Growth potential
 - How fulfilling the day-to-day responsibilities of the role are
 - Work/life balance

- **Scenarios**

When determining if the job is right for me:

- Because tangible attributes are measurable, the External Candidate will often expect to be able to filter jobs on these bases. For example:

- Compensation within certain bands
- Location by specific regions or by distance
- Flexibility in respect of remote versus hybrid versus onsite
- Evaluating the intangible attributes is harder for the External Candidate to do; these are attributes that are less searchable, and often require conversations with people in the hiring organization (such as the Recruiter or Hiring Manager). This makes it harder to complete this task earlier in the process, where there is less interaction between company and candidate
- Depending on the content strategy of the hiring organization, the External Candidate may be able to review career site collateral (e.g. a career site blog, testimonials, etc.) but it often necessitates external research, for example:
 - Leveraging social networks
 - Carrying out research on websites such as Glassdoor

● Quotes & Additional Insight

“I’m also looking for a work life balance...I think nowadays, especially after the pandemic, I value an employer who values me as a person.[\[5\]](#)

Read more in the [Quote Library](#) for [Determine if the job is right for me](#)



The #1 consideration for accepting a job with lower pay is better *work-life balance*, followed by *growth potential*. Research has found that the importance of the former has grown since the pandemic.

Indeed, Candidates are more discerning in general: for the same set of Employee Value Proposition (EVP) attributes, dropout due to EVP mismatch rose from 65% in 2020 to 73% in 2022. In other words, Candidates have become less willing to compromise on critical criteria. [\[7\]](#)[\[8\]](#)

Apply for job ▾

- **Workflows / How this job gets done:**

- Apply on company career site
- Apply on a job board website (e.g. Indeed.com) with 'Quick Apply'
- Apply in person at a brick & mortar location or mass hiring event
- Create and modify cover letter
- Create and modify résumé
- Complete certain required tasks post-application

- **Scenarios**

When applying for a job:

- Having searched for and potentially saved a job of interest on their mobile device (see [Find a job that is relevant to me](#)) the External Candidate will often wait for the first opportunity to use a desktop or laptop to complete the application. This is owing to the perceived difficulty of completing a typical job application on a mobile device
- A combination of job application characteristics (the length of a typical application; the types of questions that need to be answered; the repetitive nature of inputting the same information into multiple job applications; the need to attach files) and mobile device characteristics (form factor; connectivity) make the desktop/laptop application process preferable for many
- However, the External Candidate is more predisposed to using a mobile device for job applications that have a 'Quick Apply' option, meaning that the application can be completed on the job board with significantly fewer steps to complete
- The External Candidate may have to modify cover letters and/or résumés (if they are not already created) for different job applications, depending on how the requirements differ. Many have begun to use Generative AI to make this task more efficient and effective (see [Prepare for Job Search](#))
- **Dimensions of difference** among External Candidates:

- The technological acumen of the External Candidate plays a key factor in mitigating the application experience. Some candidate populations (for example, Manufacturing) the External Candidate may not have either the savviness or hardware to persevere through a difficult job application process. Some customers have reported implementing a process whereby these candidates are kept onsite post-interview to complete the application with a HR Professional present, to mitigate the risk of the candidate dropping off when trying to complete critical Offer tasks alone, asynchronously
- For industries characterized by peak/seasonal hiring, mass hiring events are often leveraged. This changes the application dynamic significantly

- **Quotes & Additional Insight**

“It feels like it's a lot of administrative steps, which are unnecessary at this point in time. I understand later on, maybe once you have an interview, when you'd need to go to HR and complete a few things. It's hard to invest that time when you don't know if it's going to be the right fit.” [\[1\]](#)

Read more in the [Quote Library](#) for [Apply for job](#)



Mobile applications (60.7%) surpassed desktop applications (39.3%) for the first time in 2020 [\[9\]](#). A well implemented mobile application flow has been found to have a positive impact on candidate sentiment: a benchmarking study found an increase in 4- and 5-star ratings (of the candidate experience) when candidates launched an application from a text message to their phone [\[6\]](#). However, in a study that benchmarked the application experience of high volume employers, it was found that one in three companies have an apply process that takes longer than 30 minutes for high-volume roles, and one in two

companies do not have a mobile-optimized apply process [\[10\]](#).

Track my job application

- **Workflows / How this job gets done:**

- Log on to Candidate Home to check the status of an application
- Reach out to Recruiters to check application status
- Maintain custom tracker (e.g. spreadsheet) to track concurrent applications across hiring companies

- **Scenarios**

When tracking my job application:

- The External Candidate may have to track one or more applications, across one or more hiring organizations
- In situations where there are multiple concurrent job applications across companies, the External Candidate likely has a bespoke tracker made with either digital (e.g. spreadsheet) or analog tools
- Depending on the configuration choices of Workday customers, the External Candidate may have access to *Candidate Home*, which acts as a landing page for the candidate and provides visibility into the status of a given application
- In situations where the External Candidate lacks visibility into the application status or the means to receive asynchronous updates, it is common for the candidate to reach out directly to the Recruiter responsible for filling the job requisition to ask directly

- **Quotes & Additional Insight**

“The tool I am using is Microsoft OneNote to track my applications, and to write down any notes I have. It has the job description, whether it's a remote job or a hybrid, or if it's an onsite job then it has the location. If I get a response about the application, I can put that in

there. I've applied for a lot of jobs, and it's not easy for me to remember them all."

Read more in the [Quote Library](#) for [Track my job application](#)



One benchmarking study [4] of Fortune 500 career sites reported that 0% of organizations communicated application status to the candidate after the initial email confirming submission of an application.

Engage with hiring organization throughout the application process

- **Workflows / How this job gets done:**

- Respond to correspondence from hiring company
- Reach out to Recruiter with queries
- Complete application tasks
- Coordinate interview times with HR Professional
- Participate in assessments and/or interviews
- Seek feedback in application performance

- **Scenarios**

When engaging with a hiring organization throughout the application process:

- The External Candidate invests much time and effort into the job application process, and expects their efforts to be reciprocated by hiring organizations. A common frustration reported by job candidates is the 'black hole' of communication, or ultimately being 'ghosted' by the hiring company (that is, communication ceasing and the application seemingly going nowhere)
- They also expect hiring organizations to be transparent in respect of the hiring process: how long it is anticipated to take; how many rounds of

interviews or assessment should be expected; the make-up of the interview panels, etc.

- The External Candidate also seeks to use this correspondence to help form an evaluation of the role and the hiring company: for example, the growth potential in the role and the employee experience promised by the organization (see also: [Determine if the job is right for me](#))
- Indeed, the extent to which the hiring company reciprocates and provides transparency is taken as an evaluation signal in and of itself by the External Candidate. If it is felt that hiring organizations are not putting the same level of effort into the process - for example, by updating candidates about their status, or letting them know when they're no longer in the running - the External Candidate may perceive this as a lack of respect, and feel that their valuable time is wasted. Research shows that the candidate makes assumptions that this experience mirrors the potential employee experience at the company

- **Quotes & Additional Insight**

“It kind of sets the kind of precedence or impression, for, like the company as a whole, just through their kind of hiring tendencies. If they’re not responding, being professional, then I’m not sure how it will be working under them.”

Read more in the [Quote Library](#) for

[Engage with the hiring organization throughout the application process](#)



After submitting an application, 21% of candidates experience extended gaps in contact with their recruiter, preventing any opportunities for them to seek guidance. Without a way to engage with recruiters, 29% of individuals simply abandon their application altogether [\[11\]](#) while others are likely to take another negative action such as rejecting an offer or

leaving a negative review. [\[12\]](#)

Accept or decline offer

- **Workflows / How this job gets done:**

- Weigh up offer from one or more hiring organizations
- Negotiate offer
- Make decision on whether to accept or decline
- Complete Offer task in the system

- **Scenarios**

When accepting or declining offer:

- This is a sensitive time of the process for the External Candidate, who (depending on the length of the application process) has invested a significant amount of time in trying to successfully apply for the job
- Communication between the hiring company and the External Candidate is key at this stage, particularly when the Offer stage is one fraught with potential delays on the backend that candidates do not have visibility into (e.g. approval chains) - see [Engage with the hiring organization throughout the application process](#)
- It's important to consider that the External Candidate may be going through multiple concurrent job applications, which can make the Offer stage that much more sensitive. For example, the candidate may have an offer from one hiring company while waiting to hear if an offer is forthcoming from another, perhaps for their preferred job or company
- **Dimensions of difference among External Candidates:** Internal research [\[13\]](#) uncovered some dimensions of difference between high volume candidate populations compared to those applying to jobs in 'professional' or salaried fields, such as:
 - A high degree of competition that characterizes high volume industries, meaning that hiring companies are at higher risk of losing candidates to competitors. For these candidates, the critical variables are time (which company can extend the offer the

fastest?) and compensation (which company is offering a better hourly rate?)

- More standardized offer processes with little to no scope for negotiation
- As the Offer stage is one where the External Candidate must complete a task in Workday, it is fraught with risk for companies trying to hire candidates for unskilled roles, where there is likely to be less familiarity with systems such as Workday. Given the importance of speed, noted above, a candidate having trouble logging into Workday can be the difference between securing or losing that candidate to another hiring organization

- **Quotes & Additional Insight**

“I had an offer from another company, but the pay was not good, especially for the radius that I needed to go. Right now I'm in a 10 mile radius from my home. But they wanted me to go like 20 to 30 miles out for less pay. And it just wasn't worth it to me.”



In the U.S. there are currently two unemployed people for every three job openings. Even if demand cools, low talent supply means shortages are here for the long term. Seventy-two percent of candidates received multiple offers in their last job search, with 35% reporting four or more offers. [\[14\]](#)

Key Pain Points

This section outlines some of the key pain points that have been found in research with External Candidates across various JTBD.

1. Difficulty finding a job relevant to the candidate's interests

- Candidates sometimes struggle to find the right job due to a number of factors:
 - Poorly performing search functions on company career sites. For example:
 - Lack of quality and relevance in search results (e.g. surfacing jobs not relevant to what was searched for)
 - Lack of type-ahead search to help candidates input relevant search terms
 - Out of date job listings that haven't been removed from career site
 - More broadly, candidates often have ideas about what they might be good at doing, but they struggle to convert these ideas into search queries that result in relevant jobs. Career sites typically represent the company's internal org structure and place the onus on the candidate to figure out how they fit/can contribute to the company

2. Difficulty evaluating the role and company

- Candidates have high standards in respect of what the role and the company offers them (the Employee Value Proposition, or EVP)
 - These EVP standards have evolved, particularly since the pandemic - for example, candidates place more importance on the employee experience than ever before
- However, candidates sometimes struggle to evaluate these EVP attributes, particularly in the early stages of the application process, because the relevant information to help them to make the decision is not surfaced on the career site. Companies often over-index on information

that is less relevant to today's candidates, such as information about the company culture or organizational structure

- There also tends to be a lack of transparency with regards to compensation, something that candidates place importance on but often absent from job postings

3. Difficulty applying for a job

- There are various challenges that candidates face when applying for a job, such as:
 - A company's requirement for the candidate to create an account in order to apply
 - Poor résumé parsing performance, leading to candidates having to manually enter information (exacerbated when completing many applications)
 - Depending on the field or the organization, the duration of the application is a pain point for candidates, compounded by long gaps between communications with the hiring company
 - Little or unclear guidance from the hiring company about what the hiring process will entail, particularly at the outset - for example, the length of time it is anticipated to take, how to prepare, etc.
- With the exception of 'Quick Apply' job postings on platforms such as Indeed, candidates often struggle to apply for jobs on mobile. The complications that exist irrespective of platform (described above) are compounded when candidates are dealing with small devices with limited screen real estate (e.g. having to type long form responses to questions). There are also issues with access to documents (e.g. résumés) and the perceived risk of connectivity issues resulting in the candidate losing progress and having to start again

4. Difficulty tracking job applications

- Candidates sometimes lack visibility into where their application is sitting, and understanding how far along they are in the process. They often revert to contacting the Recruiter responsible for the job requisition, who may or may not provide the candidate with an update
- Candidates applying for multiple jobs across different hiring organizations face the additional challenge of managing concurrent applications, multiplying the difficulty in understanding how their applications are progressing. Candidates have reported having to maintain custom trackers to help keep themselves up to date, although these trackers are only as good as the information that the candidate is able to ascertain about the status of an application

5. Difficulty engaging Recruiters

- Touched on above, a common frustration for Candidates is being unable to engage Recruiters responsible for the processing of their job application. Candidates often find that Recruiters - who, the data shows, are increasingly busy, and are often battling against a heavy administrative burden - do not reciprocate the level of effort that the candidate puts into the application
- This results in extended gaps in context, or sometimes even a complete discontinuation of contact (known as “ghosting”)
- When candidates do manage to engage Recruiters, research has found that Recruiters acting rudely to candidates is one of the top reasons for taking a negative action (e.g. discontinuing the application)

6. Difficulty completing Offer tasks (High Volume)

- In a FY24Q2 study, a common challenge reported by customers was difficulties that their candidates faced completing critical Offer tasks

- Customers reported that their candidates often fail to remember Workday login details and cannot access the tasks, which can result in the Candidate dropping out even at this late stage
- Some customers have reported keeping candidates on-site after an interview and verbal offer to guide the Candidate through the Offer tasks, in order to mitigate this risk - which is particularly important in a competitive labor market

About this Document

- **Author:** Stephen Ó Mathúna | Senior Researcher | Research, Analytics, and Design
- **Visual Design:** Jonathan Keyek | Principal UX Designer | Research, Analytics, and Design
- The purpose of this document is to provide additional information for the Worker User Type, specifically focused on the External Candidate.
- This UX Persona forms part of Workday's Human Centered Design (HCD) Frameworks, which provide a shared vocabulary and understanding of users to support product development, design, and strategy. Our HCD frameworks include the JTBD framework and User Type Framework, managed by the Research & Data Analytics team. You can find more information and view all of our HCD frameworks on our internal site, User Central
- This UX Persona draws from various internal and external data sources. It is primarily based on a FY24Q4 study on the Candidate Experience, which included a literature review and primary research (links are provided below to the full research reports). It also draws from past research conducted by Andrea Villa .
- If you have any questions about this document, or about our HCD Frameworks in general, please sign up here for our bi-weekly User Types & JTBD Office Hours.

Additional Resources

-  Research Results - Candidate Experience - Phase 1 - Interviews - FY24Q4
-  2023-12-01 Candidate Experience Literature Review
-  Research Results - Candidate Experience - Phase 1 - FY24Q4
- [Sign up sheet](#) for bi-weekly User Types & JTBD Office Hours
- All of our HCD Frameworks can be found on our internal site [User Central](#)

References

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- [2] Gartner (2023) Voice of the Candidate Survey Analysis (2Q23): Competition, Talent Attractors and Internal Mobility
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- [6] Talent Board (2022), 2022 North American Candidate Experience Benchmark Research Report
- [7] Gartner (2023), 5 Must-Have Labor Market Insights for Recruiting in 3Q23
- [8] Gartner (2022) EVP Attributes That Cause Organizations to Lose Job Candidates
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- [14] Gartner (2023), 5 Must-Have Labor Market Insights for Recruiting in 3Q23